

UNRAVELING THE PAST

Humanity's birthplace of Earth, **Old Terra**, was the third planet in the Sol system. Much of that history has been lost and does not figure into the timeline of the Imperium. What little records remain of the ancient ancestral birthplace of humanity are over 11,000 years old and tell of humanity reaching the stars. That journey began with the barest movement into the universe, first to a nearby satellite that orbited the Earth, and then to a red sister planet. Humans crawled further and further into space. Then, when equipped with spacecraft capable of exploring the entire Sol system, they started to walk.

These archaic Earth ships lacked **faster than light (FTL)** drives. This hindrance trapped these early space explorers primarily within their home star system. A benefit of this slow expansion allowed early humans to retain the government structure of Old Terra with minimal impact. The push to discover faster space travel influenced not only humanity's ability to explore the galaxy but the very nature of what it meant to be human.

Humanity explored space and furthered its technology, forming the **Old Empire** that grew with each passing century, gradually expanding to reach thousands

B.G. TO A.G.

The timeline is primarily broken into two eras, **Before Guild (B.G.)** and **After Guild (A.G.)**, referring to the creation of the Spacing Guild. The Spacing Guild quickly monopolized all space transport and Imperial banking through the Known Universe, changing it forever.

of worlds. The expansion of the empire pushed the boundaries of religion, leading to a schism within the Buddislamic faith, which divided into distinct branches known as the Zensunnis and the Zenshiites. The two groups expanded with the growth of the Old Empire to the outer perimeter of the **Known Universe**.

The advanced state of technology destroyed the old political structure and its essential ties to Earth. Numerous questions about humanity's place in the universe arose as they expanded ever farther from their ancestral home: How can a disunited world remain together? How do we afford the escalating cost of exploration? Where is God if we are in space? What does it mean to be human if we are born in space or upon alien soil?

THE FAUFRELUCHES SYSTEM

The **Faufreluches caste system** arose during the Old Empire, as humanity needed something or someone to focus on as a leader to maintain order. The system explained everyone's role and provided a structure for the populace to adhere to. The Houses (Major and Minor), the Imperium, and siridar fiefs (emperor-granted planetary fiefdoms) were critical for success. All the factors worked to support the others to maintain their place in the system, so removal of any one group would cause the entire structure to collapse.

The Faufreliches caste system is described in greater detail on p.37.

THINKING MACHINES

Machines have impacted humanity's development since the stone age, enhancing their survivability. 5360 B.G. saw the creation of the first thinking machines. These machines' sole function was to serve humans by performing their daily tasks. The purpose of machines evolved from being merely a tool to aiding human ingenuity in promoting stagnation as humans performed a few tasks on their own.

Eventually, humanity integrated themselves into machines, and human and machine became one. The Titans did this by placing their minds into preservation canisters, then wiring those into machine bodies creating **cymeks**. These were incredibly powerful machine entities, built along many forms, a scale that ranged from almost human-shaped and -sized to mobile vehicles, to others giant in scale with offensive capabilities, even capable of interstellar travel.

THE OLD EMPIRE EXPANDS

The Old Empire emerged after the invention of FTL drives, as humanity launched itself deeper into space much faster than before, but still at a crawl compared to the efficiency of folding space. This was a time of massive expansion, a new manifest destiny as an exodus from Earth out into the universe with hope for a brighter tomorrow on everyone's minds. As humanity spread further into space, they discovered the first cluster of other habitable planets: worlds such as Caladan, Richese, Ix, and Ecax. Then they expanded out to explore even more worlds.

The expansion lasted for over a millennium under the rule of an Imperial government. However, the vast distances between the thousand worlds under the Empire was the illusion of an empire. The Imperial government could not provide rapid support or protection for their vessels or their far-flung worlds. As time ebbed on, the Imperium became stagnant and reliant upon technology to perform even the most mundane tasks, abandoning its religious beliefs and replacing them with apathy. Towards the end of the Empire's days came the discovery of the planet Arrakis. As had been done so many times before, scientists went to the planet to determine its value to the Imperium, to assess the suitability of the planet as a home for humanity.

In its apathy, humanity had become reliant on machines and artificial intelligence (AI) in every aspect of their lives. AI had long been a goal of humans since the time of Old Terra. This simplistic vision would lead to their eventual downfall. That began with Tlaloc, the revolutionary who, in a failed attempt to awaken humanity from its stupor, turned to more radical means to overthrow the Old Empire. A small but brilliant and influential group of twenty followers formed around Tlaloc. They took on the names of legendary individuals from human history and called themselves the **Titans**.

THE TIME OF TITANS

The Titans were composed of scientists, geniuses, and fallen nobility, and they possessed the tools needed to topple the Imperium. Xerxes, an exiled prince, gave financial backing to the plan of **General Agamemnon**, who outmaneuvered the Old Empire to allow the technical genius **Barbarossa** unfettered access to the Imperial network. Agamemnon deduced that turning thinking machines into an army would let them topple the Imperium with minimal violence. While the military was skilled and well-trained, they were no match for the near-endless ranks of thinking machines scattered throughout human space. The defeated human army saved the dethroned Emperor in 1287 B.G., and the Titans assumed control of the Known Universe.

In response and out of necessity, 10,000 free human systems united, forming the **League of Nobles** to oppose the Titans. As the union solidified, Bovko Manresa became their first viceroy. Manresa had established a refuge for those fleeing the thinking machines and offered the world of Salusa Secundus as a forward operation base.

Once in control, the Titans divided the universe into small fiefdoms and installed themselves as dictators, ruling with brutal and cruel efficiency. Much like the now-subjected humans under their control, the Titans relied heavily on thinking machines and AIs to rule the planets they held. The Titans themselves focused on more pleasurable pursuits of sex, combat, and other diversions.

When an accident took Tlaloc's life, the Titans were reminded of their mortality. Though long-lived due to life-extending procedures, the specter of death hung close to them. Following in the footsteps of Cogitor Arn Eklo, their advisor, they would place their brains into preservation tanks. Unlike **cogitors**, whose brains were in sensory deprivation, preservation tanks allowed the Titans to live for thousands of years, complementing humanity's destiny.

The Titans became **cymeks**, nearly unstoppable weaponized mechanical bodies capable of surviving for thousands of years but remaining vulnerable to hostile conditions. Their sensors acted as replacement for all sensory stimulus, and thus, they waited, seemingly immortal.

NOTABLE TITANS

While all twenty of the titans were incredibly powerful, only a few were of note. These were Agamemnon, Ajax, Alexander, Barbarossa, Dante, Hecate, Juno, Tamerlane, Tlaloc, and Xerxes.

THE RISE OF THE CYMEKS

Agamemnon continued to rule the Titans for nearly a century. The mastermind of their rise would also be the key to their downfall. Barbarossa continued to evolve the computer network. He was never quite satisfied with the results until finally installing aggression and ambition.

The fatal blow to Agamemnon's rule came from Xerxes and its desire for leisure. The cymek Titan gave more

control to the AI that became sentient and birthed **Omnium**. The ambitious AI quickly infected all the Titan worlds, usurping them in the process. While Barbarossa's program prohibited Omnium from hurting the Titans, it left them no other option but to serve it or be powerless. The cymeks became part of Omnium's thinking machine army. They served Omnium for a millennium.

Omnium enforced its programming, such as the desires of its former rulers, subjugating in the process. While the cymeks' human nature distracted them and gave them other avenues of interest, Omnium had only one purpose: to replace humanity with logical machines. The AI ruthlessly carried out that task for centuries and murdered countless billions.

While he served, Agamemnon plotted revenge for nearly 900 years, awaiting the moment to overthrow Omnium. The former cymek leader vented his frustration against humanity. The Titan General fathered multiple children, with Vorian Atreides as the sole survivor. Agamemnon found the rest wanting and slew them. Vorian became a trustee of Omnium, working on starships and traveling between the **Synchronized Worlds**.

The final spark to the war that would be called the **Butlerian Jihad** was the child of **Serena Butler** and her lover **Xavier Harkonnen**. She was the daughter of the viceroy of the League of Nobles, an outspoken proponent for the **Unallied Planets**, and he was the military commander of the League's forces. Serena was captured and believed killed by Barbarossa on Giedi Prime but was in fact transferred to Earth under the watchful sensors of the independent thinking machine **Erasmus**, in the service of Omnium.

The League's forces continued to battle the thinking machines, as the **Sorceresses of Rossak** began their breeding program to create the ultimate psychic to combat Omnium. The nascent program would become the foundation of the **Kwisatz Haderach** and the **Bene Gesserit Sisterhood**. In the shadow of the war, scientist Tio Holtzman, who derived the theory called the **Holtzman Effect**, began working with young Norma Cenva, who developed space 'folding'. Lastly, Aurelius Venport, while far away from the front lines, discovered the key to the universe and humanity's destiny, the true properties of the **spice melange** (or more simply, "spice").

Erasmus had a fascination with humanity and expressed it through dissection of them. Serena was pregnant with Xavier's child while Erasmus' prisoner. She befriended Vorian. Erasmus became obsessed with Butler. To have more time with her, it killed her child Manion, who became the first martyr of the oncoming war. Enraged, Butler attacked Erasmus, causing a human uprising against their machine masters. The revolt was quelled and, in the chaos, Butler and Iblis Ginjo escaped along with Vorian aboard his ship and fled to the League of Nobles' home base.

THE THREE FACTIONS

The universe essentially broke into three distinct factions, each with their own motivations.

- ❖ **The League Worlds**, under the control of the League of Nobles, including Giedi Prime and Junction.
- ❖ **The Synchronized Worlds**, ruled by the thinking machines and then controlled by Omnium - except IX.
- ❖ **The Unallied Planets** (as the League Worlds called them) were left to their own devices either by choice, or because they were considered irrelevant due to poor resources. Examples included Arrakis and Caladan.

about how the machines operated. There were many inconclusive battles in the first years of the war, with neither side able to claim victory. These pointless skirmishes included the assault on Bela Tegeuse and the many times the League repelled Omnium's forces attacking their homeworld of Salusa Secundus. Many of the worlds freed by the League's attacks were considered partial victories. While they had liberated the planets, Omnium exterminated all humanity on them before it sent its consciousness to the next world.

Nearly twenty years into the Butlerian Jihad, humanity had suffered large losses from suicidal robotic forces. A critical turning point occurred when Omnium Prime began attacking and conquering the Unallied Planets, starting with Tyndall and Bellos. These newfound locations became forward operating posts for the thinking machines.

The League of Nobles debated internally what the best course of action would be as the Unallied Worlds refused them the resources required to defend themselves. Out of necessity, they chose to protect all human worlds to deny the enemy any support. The League rescued many, such as the peaceful Zensunni, and the mercenaries of Ginaz joined the cause, providing valuable tactical skills.

VenKee Enterprises formed under Aurelius Venport and Tuk Keedair, to distribute spice throughout the universe and trade with the League of Nobles. The company's profits skyrocketed from sales of spice and glowglobes created by Norma Cenva. Sometime later, Norma Cenva provided them the secret that would revolutionize the Known Universe. She had discovered how to reliably 'fold space'. At that time, this form of long-range space travel was unpredictable, with one in ten ships simply vanishing.

A devious plan to corrupt the Omnium mind was executed, destroying eight instances of it before it was stopped by Omnium Prime and Erasmus. During this chaos, the Titans temporarily escaped, then took control of the planet Bela Tegeuse and converted willing volunteers into a deadly army of **Neo-cymeks**. While this new threat emerged, the **Cogitors** proposed a possible truce between humanity and the machines, which resulted in the death of Serena and provided a new martyr to reinvigorate humanity to fight on, pressing VenKee Enterprises to provide their fledgling **space folding** technology in service to the League.

The war raged for years. Then, Yorek Thurr, a League traitor, provided the inspiration for the **Omnium Scourge**. The machine-made virus engineered by Erasmus decimated the human population. A cure was found in the form of the spice melange, which transformed human society fundamentally, affecting almost every aspect of life. Finally, Vorian led an attack on the Titans, destroying them and killing his father, hastening the final stage of the conflict.

THE DAWN OF THE BUTLERIAN JIHAD

After centuries under constant threat, coupled with Serena's urging over the loss of her child, 201 B.G. witnessed the beginning of the Butlerian Jihad. The League of Nobles on Salusa Secundus led the assault on Omnium's Synchronized Worlds. They began with Earth. The forces followed the two religious leaders—its High Priestess Serena and the Grand Patriarch Iblis—along with the Generals Vorian and Xavier. In response, Omnium worked with Erasmus to eradicate all human life on Earth. The League captured the Earth-based Omnium for experimentation, and the League of Nobles used atomics on the barren world to win the battle. Such was humanity's first recorded victory against the machines in the war of humankind versus thinking machines.

Omnium Prime relocated itself to Corrin as it prepared for what was to come while Erasmus escaped the human Jihad by fleeing to Corrin. Erasmus' fascination with humanity never ceased, and the conscious machine struck a bet with Omnium that a human could be as logical as a machine. This bet would eventually lead to the creation of the first human **Mentats**.

The sentient AI continually pressed a logical and ordered attack. Vorian, who knew the ways of machines, provided tactical guidance to the League of Nobles

THE FALL OF THE THINKING MACHINES

The end of the Butlerian Jihad occurred over the planet Corrin, where Omnium gathered all its forces for one last fatal assault against Salusa Secundus. The League discovered the plot and prepared its retaliation, assaulting the unprotected Synchronized Worlds, blasting them with atomics and destroying everything. The opposing forces met at Corrin. The League trapped Omnium Prime with a scrambler network: a device created by Norma Cenva that used the Holtzman effect to destroy the gel in thinking machines. Before its destruction, Omnium sent a radio signal into an unknown region of space, laced with a copy of itself. Erasmus' human test subject Gilbertus Albans escaped with Erasmus' brain before the scrambler network went online.

THE BIRTH OF AN EMPIRE

The destruction of the thinking machines on Corrin ended the Jihad, and the leader, Faykan Butler, changed his last name to Corrino to honor what had happened. He then created House Corrino and crowned himself **Emperor**. The Orange Catholic Bible issued the commandment, "Thou shalt not make a machine in the likeness of a human mind." That decree was enforced and lived on.

Faykan Corrino became the first **Padishah Emperor** through a series of political moves and manipulation of humanity's fear of thinking machines. The new empire became a hereditary rule taken up by House Corrino after the Battle of Corrin. The title was used by the leader of House Corrino for more than 10,000 years.

The Houses, both Major and Minor, were an ancient part of the Old Empire and what would become the Imperium. They had evolved along with humanity, with different lineages that rose and fell as the engine of time turned. In the modern empire, a **Major House** controlled at least one world as the primary base of operations, and possibly many more. The **Minor Houses** had a single moon, territory, or some other strategic or valuable asset under their control, owing fidelity to a Major House that they were bound to. These Houses acquired their rank through ancient blood lineage, wealth, or by grant of the Imperial throne. The empire operated as an interstellar fiefdom.

The Houses banded together to form the **Landsraad**, composed of the noble Houses who were overseen by the Padishah Emperor and run by its **High Council**. Both Major and Minor Houses were welcomed, with the Major Houses being the only members elected to the High Council. The Landsraad met frequently, allowing nobles a place to air grievances, discuss matters impacting the universe, and formalize deals, whether contracts, feuds, or other business and territorial matters.

The Landsraad made decisions by vote, with the Major Houses having considerable power, seconded by the Imperial throne, and lastly, the Minor Houses. Even the Emperor had to adhere to decrees made by the High Council, as the combined might of the Major Houses nearly matched that of the Imperium. The High Council ruled the Landsraad and was selected from the members of the Major Houses by vote. These representatives were second only to the Emperor in influence. The Houses were expected to act as the Landsraad decreed.

The Major Houses were originally granted worlds at the behest of the Emperor, later becoming hereditary akin to the throne. Fiefdoms frequently took the form of a main homeworld that paid a tithe to the throne through their exports and were responsible for the enforcement of the laws and services to the Empire. Each Major House was allowed a small army, a coat-of-arms, and authority to rule the world in adherence to their beliefs. The latter led to some worlds being paradises welcome to all, while others operated on the backs of enslaved people.

The nobles of Minor Houses held wealth, privilege, and political power, but only a fraction of that held by the Major Houses. The nobles of this class found themselves like guests, capable of moving through the universe with greater ease than Major House members. They overlooked the internecine battle between Houses—the formalized and limited **War of Assassins**—unless it affected them directly. These elite were frequently found in locations with stronger trade or business, as their status required more upkeep.

THE GREAT SCHOOLS ARE FOUNDED

In the wake of Butlerian Jihad the remaining members of the Sorceresses of Rossak moved toward their next evolutionary step, forming the Bene Gesserit under Raquella Berto-Anirul. Their order assumed roles once held by the thinking machines, taking on positions of leadership and influence working with and within the League of Nobles. The Sorceresses were the originators of the breeding program for the Kwizatz Haderach, responsible for creating the perfect human being and creating a record of the bloodlines of the noble families. The Rossak Sorceresses aided in the Butlerian Jihad and acquired much political power in its aftermath, due to their influence and the reservoir of knowledge possessed by the Mother Superior, reaching back to the early days of humankind. The organization used the trappings of religion to move its grand plans forward to acquire more power and chart the course of humankind through their prescience. They operated in the background, pushing political players as needed through marriage, terror, and other, more subtle means.

The Butlerian Jihad battlefields were brutal nightmares that broke the minds of doctors dealing with the massive numbers of casualties. **Dr. Rajid Suk**, one of the

most exceptional battlefield surgeons that ever lived, was one of the few who did not break. He made significant contributions to the League of Nobles and laid the foundation for his grandnephew Mohandas. Possessing even greater skill, Mohandas opened the **Suk Medical School**, which surpassed all others, and the doctors there were known for never betraying a patient. Graduates of the Suk School were considered the best doctors in the Imperium.

Gilbertus Albans joined the League of Nobles while hiding the Erasmus pod and founded the **order of Mentats**. While the order slowly flourished, the Butlerian Jihad cults were ever-present, and many Mentats joined their cause to cement the end of all thinking machines. The Mentats took the places of the thinking machines, but unlike either the Bene Gesserit or Spacing Guild, they did not acquire political power as an order. Instead, their unique skills helped them become tools of those in power, serving as advisors rather than as leaders or shapers of history. Though essential for the economic growth of the Imperium, they are more servants waiting to be assigned than leaders in their own rights.

THE GREAT COMPANIES

Norma Cenva's discovery of the prescient powers of spice enabled safe space folding and solidified the future of the company that became the **Foldspace Shipping Company**, later the **Spacing Guild**, or more commonly 'the Guild'. The Guild established a monopoly on all space travel and banking, as all who wanted to travel quickly through space were required to go through them. Thus, the Guild enforces peace through financial stability: adhere to their dictates and ensure **Guild Peace** or lose access to faster-than-light interstellar travel, and thus face economic suicide and financial ruin, losing access to many of the funds and the ability to make transactions through the Guild Bank. Simply put, a House that defies the Guild is denied their range of essential services and is at a fatal disadvantage transporting their goods and participating in the great market of the Landsraad.

The Shipping Company birthed the **Combine Honnete Ober Advancer Mercantiles** (CHOAM) that controls nearly every economic contract or deal throughout the Known Universe. No legal arrangement occurred without paying a percentage to CHOAM. The company was composed of the Emperor and the Landsraad with the Bene Gesserit and Spacing Guild as silent partners in profits paid to shareholders. The quickest route to wealth in the Imperium was through CHOAM, and it resulted in numerous assassinations and initial conflicts while on the path towards acceptance and acknowledgment of its primacy in the empire's financial power.

CHOAM was run like a corporation with a board of directors and profit shares, and was open to the public to purchase shares for those that could afford them.

Members of the Landsraad from the Great Houses held more power on the board of directors than the Minor Houses. Still, all were subjected to the Emperor, who gave and assigned shares. The balance built into the Imperium stayed the worst of the Emperor's demands with a focus on backstabbing rather than outright confronting the other members. The political power of CHOAM is without question as the wealth it provides is key to each House, government, and organization. Much as the Spacing Guild is dependent on spice, while CHOAM is dependent upon the Guild as its lifeline.

THE GREAT CONVENTION

Ultimately, all the Major and Minor Houses had essentially the same shared needs: commerce and the ability to travel across the vastness of space. Now lacking a machine enemy, each House shared the same threat to their existence: the very arsenals that they had amassed to fight in the Jihad could now be turned against one another. To ensure that their needs were continued to be met and that the threat of attack within the Landsraad was mitigated, the Great Houses signed a treaty establishing an alliance to stop anyone from ever again using atomic weapons on one another and on their holdings, particularly upon their subjects. This **Great Convention** saw the Imperial throne, Houses, and Spacing Guild reach an accord. It marked a historic moment in humanity's evolution, paralleling ancient meetings of Old Terra by banning weapons of mass destruction. After the horrific Omnium plagues unleashed during the years of the Jihad, the strictures of the Great Convention also firmly prohibited all use of biological plagues and weaponry.

The agreement stated that no House could use atomics against humans again, as human life was deemed too precious after having lost so many in the Butlerian Jihad. Such an action would cause all the remaining parties to exterminate the offender. This had the side effect of a resultant move towards use of medieval weapons for combat. Further refinements included limitations on the usage of lasguns and shield technology, so intertwined as they were with weapons of mass destruction due to the Holtzman Effect.

Penalties for breaking the Great Convention were severe, even catastrophic, for any House found guilty. Even the most minor of transgressions meant temporary censure and denial of services from CHOAM and the Spacing Guild, while severe violations led to forfeitures of shares in CHOAM, seizure of property by the Emperor, and license for destruction by any enemies—or former allies—within the Landsraad. Any territory or industries seized as a result were to be divided by the Emperor among other Houses, making defiance of the Great Convention a risk few would dare to take. Placing the mechanism for enforcement into the hands of 'external' agencies like CHOAM—ostensibly owned by all the Landsraad—and the Spacing Guild meant that justice had a semblance of impartiality and fairness.



LASGUNS, SHIELDS, & THE GREAT CONVENTION

When a lasgun beam hits a shield, the effect is instant, devastating, and pseudo-atomic. A pseudo-atomic explosion occurs that lays waste to the area and anything within it, possibly even for miles around. For this reason, the Great Convention has outlawed the use of this effect in any way, in the same way it outlaws the use of atomic weapons.

For most player characters, that will be enough of a warning. Unfortunately, some players may still think that a few suicide troops with lasguns might end a rival quickly and efficiently. They would be wrong, and the fact that even the Harkonnens will not stoop to his method should be a clue as to the terrible consequences that will occur. Most Houses will not take lasguns into a battle where they even suspect a shield may be present.

Whether it is accidental or intended, any lasgun/shield interaction breaks the Great Convention,

the importance of which cannot be overstated. It is an agreement around which peace in the universe remains possible. Nobles want to know that when they are shielded, they are safe, and that there are limits to the myriad ways their enemies will attempt to destroy them. Anyone who breaks this status quo for any reason threatens to shake the very foundations of civilization in the Imperium.

This means that any House that knowingly or unknowing breaks any of the rules of the Great Convention will be crushed. The Landsraad cannot afford to allow any other option. The errant House will be destroyed, its holdings divided among its peers (making them less inclined towards mercy anyway). For the players, their characters, their characters' families, and their House, this means the game is over.

No warnings, no excuses, no apologies, no quarter.

The accord also regulated that the Imperial government could not take sides in House vs. House conflicts and should either act as or appoint a neutral arbiter. Lastly, the Emperor was given full authority in matters related to the Butlerian Jihad.

A NEW ORDER EMERGES

The end of Butlerian Jihad and the defeat of the millennium-long enemy saw humanity on the cusp of a new destiny. The old order was gone, the threat that held humanity together was gone, and an unknown future awaited. Anyone could declare themselves emperor, but without a rigid structure, the Imperium would all fall apart and into chaos. While different factions worked to hold the universe together, none could do it alone.

The League of Nobles survived the Butlerian Jihad, with new people claiming nobility and positions of power.

The Spacing Guild came into existence out of a monopoly on the ability to safely fold space and acquired the interstellar banks' trade less than a century after the Butlerian Jihad. This monumental step in human evolution created the need for a new Imperial Calendar, After Guild (A.G.), because of the importance of this event and the extent that the new technology would change the future. Much of the Spacing Guild's initial political power emerged from the Great Convention that established the new Imperium for the universe, ensuring that the benefits for cooperation far outweighed any gains for non-compliance and violating the peace.

In near-perfect synchrony with the Spacing Guild, the Padishah Empire, the Great Houses, and CHOAM also formed and established the basis of the new Imperium in 1 A.G. upon the shattered remains of the Old Empire. New universal governance was needed to lead humanity. A bargain was arranged during the Great Convention with the Imperium (House Corrino) as the ruler of the Known Universe in a shared feudal agreement with the Landsraad, Bene Gesserit, and the Spacing Guild. The Empire grew over the millennia to encompass more than a million planets across the galaxy.

A DELICATE BALANCE OF POWER

The Imperium under House Corrino ruled for over 10,000 years with a delicate balance of deception, persuasion, and military force. This balance was adhered to by the Spacing Guild, Bene Gesserit, and the Landsraad. While they were considered equal partners, it required all the combined forces of the others to match that of Emperor requiring them to work together. All the universe's economic business was executed through CHOAM, which was critical in assisting the

Order of the Mentats to assign members who were in great demand from each universal power player.

There were exceptions to this peace, such as when one aggressive House desired removal of the then-current Emperor and blasted Salusa Secundus with atomics, turning it into a devastated wasteland. That emperor survived the assault, and later turned the remains of the planet into a prison and training ground of the **Sardaukar**. These soldiers were the Padishah Emperor's elite military force, in service to House Corrino, feared throughout the Known Universe for their capability and loyalty to the throne. It was widely believed that no army could match the Sardaukar of House Corrino.

THE SECRET OF THE SPACING GUILD

To maintain their immense power and reach throughout the Known Universe, the Spacing Guild depended upon their ability to create **Guild Navigators**; the secret of the Guild's ability to travel interstellar distances safely and quickly. This made them hugely dependent on the spice, for the Navigators themselves were humans exposed to incredible amounts of spice in a secret process that granted them a limited form of prescience. For over 10,000 years, the Guild dominated without question.

Much like the Bene Gesserit and Mentats, the Guild assumed another role previously held by the thinking machines: providing transport across vast distances of space, the Navigators' predictive capabilities expanding their consciousness to enable the complex mathematical processes required, that only machines could perform prior. Like each of the others, the inner workings of their organization were kept secret. The Guild's secretive nature kept outsiders from getting even a glimpse inside their operations, obscuring its structure and roles within. The roles known to outsiders were limited to the Navigators, a few administrators, and a handful of executives who interacted with the Emperor.

SWORDMASTERS AND THE SUK SCHOOL

Two other important schools worthy of consideration also arose in this time, and though neither was as influential as the Bene Gesserit, the Mentats, or the Spacing Guild, they were nonetheless hugely useful to all Houses—Major and Minor. The first was the Swordmasters of Ginaz, battle-trained warriors of superlative skill, capable of defending House-members within their estates and training their soldiers to incredible discipline. The other was the doctors of the Suk School of Medicine, described prior. Though each had many rivals, none could attain and maintain the standard of excellence that made the Ginaz and Suk schools synonymous with the services they provided. When one spoke of a 'swordmaster' or a 'doctor', it was assumed that these were products of the Ginaz or the Suk schools, as no others would be worthy of mention.

THE IMPERIUM TODAY

The Known Universe in the year of 10,081 is ruled by **Padishah Emperor Shaddam Corrino IV**. After the discovery of space folding and the explosive growth of the Known Universe, recent expansion has slowed. Now, the borders of the Known Universe are only slightly larger than the Imperium itself, having increased ever so slowly over the centuries as space outside it was explored and charted.

Millennia upon millennia have passed as the Padishah Empire remains in control, though by the time of Emperor Shaddam IV, the Imperium is stressed, inefficient, and bloated. For several generations a quiet revolutionary movement has been building among certain noble Houses, the Noble Commonwealth, with the aim of breaking apart the vast, monolithic Imperium into smaller, independent, and competitive holdings. The Noble Commonwealth has been known to foster some terrorist activities to make their point known.

The importance of spice is widespread, making it the single most valuable and sought-after substance in the galaxy. The desire for commerce and evolution continues undaunted.

Humanity continues to evolve, learn, and to succumb to its need for power and self-destruction. Charismatic leaders have risen to change the course of humankind, only to fall and be replaced by others, in an endless cycle of change. The one thing that unites the entirety of the universe is the spice melange.



TIMELINE OF HUMAN HISTORY

Eras are Before Guild (B.G.) and After Guild (A.G.). Dates identified only by era are unknown and are placed approximately. Many dates are approximate or contested.

11,000 B.G.

The Space Age begins and there is a revelation about how religion operates.

B.G.

The Old Empire begins with humankind governed by an expanding Imperial body of planets.

2,200 B.G.

Several scientists and philosophers transplant their brains into preservation canisters, becoming Cogitors.

B.G.

Over ideological differences, Buddislam splits into two different factions: Zensunnis and Zenshiites.

1,381 B.G.

The Zensunni split from the Maometh, the third Muhammed religion.

B.G.

Yanshup Ashkoko, a scholar in service to Shakkad the Wise, discovers the spice melange on Arrakis.

B.G.

Arrakis is evaluated for future colonization and planetary value for the Empire.

1,287 B.G.

The Old Empire's last emperor is dethroned and lost to history.

1,287 B.G.

The time of the Titans begins.

B.G.

The Titans reprogram computers and AI, giving them aggression. They use them to conquer the Old Empire.

B.G.

The Titans divide up the empire into fiefdoms under their control.

B.G.

The League of Nobles is birthed on the systems' edges. It fights back from Salusa Secundus.

B.G.

Arrakis is abandoned.

1,280 B.G.

The Titans' leader dies. Using advanced technology, the other Titans transform themselves into cymeks.

1,192–1,183 B.G.

The Walgis Rebellion.

1,182 B.G.

The aggressive AI Omnium takes control of all Titan planets, creating the Synchronized Worlds and making all the Titans its servants.

1,182 B.G.

In response to Omnium's actions, the League of Nobles limits all A.I. usage.

1,182 B.G.

Omnium attacks the League of Nobles and is rebuffed.

1,182 B.G.

Believing the rise and attack of the machines adhered to the Kralizec Prophecy, the Buddislamics flee to wander the universe.

400 B.G.

The Sorceresses of Rossak start their initial breeding record program. This will become the heart of the Kwisatz Haderach program.

250 B.G.

Manion Butler is born.

236 B.G.

Piers Harkonnen is born.

223 B.G.

Vorian Atreides is born.

221 B.G.

Serena Butler is born.

203 B.G.

Tio Holtzman creates the scrambler shield to combat the thinking machines.

203 B.G.

Omnium seizes control of Giedi Prime and sends out thousands of deep space probes to copy itself on numerous other worlds, creating operating stations.

203 B.G.

Selim, a Zensunni outcast on Arrakis, becomes the first person to ride a sandworm. He gains the surname 'Wormrider'.

203 B.G.

The League of Nobles liberate Giede Prime.

203 B.G.

Under the employ of Tio Holtzman, Norma Cenva creates suspensors.

202 B.G.

The spice melange's commercial value is discovered.

202 B.G.

Holtzman creates protective shields.

201 B.G.

On Earth, humankind riots against Omnium and the Titans.

201 B.G.

In response to the revolt, Omnium eradicates all human life on Earth.

201 B.G.

Spice melange is introduced commercially to the League of Nobles.

200–108 B.G.

The Butlerian Jihad.

201 B.G.

The League of Nobles attacks Earth with atomics, destroying all the thinking machines on the planet. Earth is left a shattered, uninhabitable wasteland.

198 B.G.

The Jihad's crusaders execute their first joint attack on Bela Tegeuse. Neither side can declare victory in the battle.

197 B.G.

The Corrin Omnium launches an unsuccessful attack on the League of Nobles world Salusa Secundus.

195 B.G.

The League of Nobles suffers a disastrous defeat at the Honru Massacre.

185 B.G.

Gilbertus Albans is born.

185 B.G.

Work on space folding begins.

176 B.G.

Erasmus wagers Omnium that humans can learn as a computer and begins teaching Albans.

175 B.G.

Vorian Atreides develops a technique that can cripple instances of the Omnium A.I.

174 B.G.

Cenva builds the first foldship on Poritrin and the Zensunni use it to flee to Arrakis.

173 B.G.

Kolar, the first spacefolding shipyard, is established in space.

108 B.G.

Omnis unleashes a genetically engineered virus on multiple worlds. It kills billions of the League's populaces.

108 B.G.

The fanatic Cult of Serena starts and begins destroying all machines.

108 B.G.

The League of Nobles destroys most of the Omnis AI throughout the universe and declares the Butlerian Jihad to be officially over.

107 B.G.

The Humanities Medical Commission is founded by Mohandes Suk and Raquella Berto-Anirul. After the Jihad, it travels the universe aiding those in need.

88 B.G.

The Arrakis Zensunni are assaulted by raiders and some are enslaved.

88 B.G.

Cenva discovers that prescience through spice allows flawless space folding.

88 B.G.

The Humanities Medical Commission travels to Rossak to battle the Rossak Epidemic, a mutated strain of the Omnis virus.

88 B.G.

Faykan Butler uses the Cult of Serena to ascend to Viceroy and institutes the law that no machine can be created in the likeness of a human mind.

88 B.G.

The Corrin Omnis broadcasts a copy of itself into deep space and uses the enslaved humans as a shield to slow the League of Nobles' assault. The League attacks anyway; destroying the last instance of Omnis and all remaining thinking machines.

88 B.G.

Gilbertus saves Erasmus' memory core, even though possession of a thinking machine is considered a death sentence.

88 B.G.

The Foldspace Shipping Company is established by Adrien Venport and Tuk Keedair.

88 B.G.

Faykan Butler takes on the last name Corrin and declares himself Emperor of Humanity.

88 B.G.

Fleeing the slavers on Arrakis, the Zensunni move into the deep desert and adapt to the harsh environment.

88 B.G.

Ix and Richese survive the Cult of Serena's fanatical assault on machines, unscathed.

B.G.

Mohannas Suk establishes the Suk Medical School.

B.G.

Under the leadership of Raquella Berto-Anirul, the Rossak Sorceresses become the Bene Gesserit, founding their Mother School on Wallach IX.

B.G.

Albans establishes the Order of Mentats.

86 B.G.

House Atreides is founded as reward for actions during the Butlerian Jihad.

5 B.G.

CHOAM is founded.

1 B.G.

The Spacing Guild is birthed from the Foldspace Shipping Company and establishes itself as a key force in the universe. This marks the pivotal event that changes the course of humanity's destiny.

1 A.G.

The Imperial throne, the Spacing Guild, CHOAM, and the Landsraad all work together, forming the Imperium as it will be for generations.

A.G.

The Great Houses convene to sign the Great Convention, outlawing the use of atomics against humans. Anyone breaking the convention is open to attack without warning.

A.G.

Salusa Secundus is destroyed by atomic weapons and the Imperial capital is moved to Kaitain.

A.G.

The Bene Gesserit creates the art of thought-merging and memory transfer that becomes the backbone of the Sisterhood's strength.

6,600 A.G.

First Wild Reverend Mother appears.

8,677 A.G.

House Atreides moves to Caladan.

10,108 A.G.

House Richese loses its economic war against Ix.

10,110 A.G.

Vladimir Harkonnen is born.

10,114 A.G.

House Richese loses control of Arrakis and House Harkonnen is granted it as a fief.

10,118 A.G.

Hasimir Fenring, the failed Kwisatz Haderach, is born.

10,119 A.G.

Shaddam IV is born.

10,140 A.G.

Leto Atreides is born.

10,153 A.G.

Vladimir Harkonnen takes control of Arrakis.

10,153 A.G.

Imperial Planetologist Pardot Kynes is sent to Arrakis to discover a way to replicate spice.

10,154 A.G.

With assistance from Emperor Elrood IX, the Bene Tleilax assume control of Ix.

10,154 A.G.

Project Amal is started.

10,154 A.G.

Lady Jessica is born.

10,156 A.G.

The first no-field is created by Chobyn, a Richese scientist.

10,156 A.G.

Shaddam Corrin IV ascends to the Imperial throne.

A.G.

The Bene Tleilax takes control of Ix, with secret assistance from Emperor Shaddam IV.

10,162 A.G.

Irulan Corrin is born.

10,166 A.G.

A war starts between House Ecac and House Moritani.

10,171 A.G.

Leto gains significant support in the Landsraad.

10,171 A.G.

The Bene Gesserit devise a plan to make Lady Jessica Leto's concubine.

10,174 A.G.

House Atreides gains the service of Gurney Halleck.

10,175 A.G.

Shaddam IV initiates the Great Spice War.

10,175 A.G.

House Atreides frees Ix from Tleilaxu control.

10,175 A.G.

House Vernius regains control of Ix under Rhombur.

10,175 A.G.

Paul Atreides is born.

10,181 A.G.

The current year.

OVERVIEW OF THE IMPERIUM

After more than 10,000 years of Corrino rule, the Imperium is poised between the new and the old: subtle technologies and advantages allow the elite to live extended lives of opulence and wealth, while laborers and others less fortunate are virtual peasants, their lives rigidly proscribed within the highly structured feudal society.

THE LANDSRAAD AND THE GREAT CONVENTION

All the Houses—Major and Minor alike—are governed collectively by a council called the Landsraad, which is headed by the hereditary Emperor Corrino, with his own military reserves to enforce order upon his enemies, should any emerge to challenge his rule. The Landsraad is organized through a set of rules known as the Great Convention, the political compact that governs all.

All within the Landsraad swear allegiance to the Emperor, but most Houses within the Landsraad strive and scramble for influence and power, usually represented in wealth and military supremacy. Politics within the Landsraad are as commonplace as they are vicious,

with different Houses jockeying for capital and influence, striving against one another, using espionage and other tactics to spy upon one another, to war discretely, and to thwart the ambitions of their rivals. Meanwhile, the Emperor sits above it all, picking favorites and ally-ing discretely with one House against another, giving advantage to one while weakening another, changing his favorites as they become relevant.

The rules of the Great Convention prevent open warfare between Houses under most circumstances unless, of course, sanctioned by the Emperor, as well as providing provisions for the protection of the civilian populaces governed by those Houses. A safety valve exists in the form of *kanly*, the art of vendetta, providing a legitimate means of one House waging war against another through assassins. The use of the ultimate weapons, atomics, and deadly biological plagues is prohibited entirely (as mentioned previously).

THE TRIAD OF POWER

Power in the Imperium is held between three great factions: the Landsraad alliance of Houses Major and



Minor; the Emperor and his fearsome legions of fanatical Sardaukar soldiers; and a third force, a coalition between the Spacing Guild, which provides transport throughout the Imperium, and the omnipresent business conglomerate known as CHOAM, which governs all commerce within the Imperium. Though CHOAM and the Spacing Guild are distinct and separate entities—the Spacing Guild even has its own Guild Bank—they act in lockstep with one another, as the open market is worthless without the means to transport goods within the Imperium.

Between these titans, the vestige of peace is held, and the semblance of civilization continues to march forward.

THE SPICE MELANGE

One thing makes the existing power structure within the Imperium possible: the spice melange, an organic substance which bestows longevity, enhanced awareness, and allows prescient visions of the future to come. Despite its beneficial qualities, the spice is a double-edged sword: it is also highly addictive, and withdrawal can often be deadly.

This miraculous substance is found in only one place in the entire universe: the planet Arrakis. This desert world,

seemingly barren save for its gigantic sandworms and fierce nomadic native inhabitants called the **Fremen**, is the most important place in the universe.

Wars have been fought over possession of the spice, for the one who controls the spice holds the wheel about which the universe turns. Stewardship of Arrakis is one of the most valuable holdings any House may possess, as the spice is as essential as it is expensive. The House with the right to mine spice on *Dune* becomes a target for every other House, so lucrative is the spice trade, which is in itself another balancing force. For this reason, it is explicitly prohibited for the Emperor himself to possess Arrakis, as this would tip the balance of power irrevocably.

With the Butlerian Edicts, humankind is forbidden to make machines that can think, and thus it once more falls to humankind to fill this void. Spice grants enhanced mental acuity and awareness, and as a result, many specialized fields of training take advantage of this. In addition to the Bene Gesserit (described on p.55) and the Spacing Guild (following), some other organizations known as Great Schools use spice or training aided by spice to reach pinnacles of human development and discipline. They are described in **The Great Schools**, on p.34.



THE SPACING GUILD

The greatest challenge to the cohesion of the Imperium and the rule of the Emperor is the vastness of space and the immense distance separating the various worlds the Imperium encompasses. In the early era of space travel, ships would embark on generations-long journeys to find habitable worlds. Faster-than-light travel was unreliable. Colonies disappeared into the dark, twinkling tapestry of space, never to be heard from again. Hundreds of years would pass between contact between planets. The complex computations required for foldspace travel were only possible through the use of thinking computers, which were forbidden after the Butlerian Jihad. While smaller spaceships were, and still are, capable of inter-system travel, true interstellar travel, voyaging between star systems, was—and still is—so time-intensive and with an element of risk that non-foldspace travel has few benefits.

A solution to this came with the development of the Navigators of the Spacing Guild, humans mutated through extreme exposure to spice for this particular purpose. Their spice-granted limited prescient ability allows Navigators to safely guide an interstellar vessel as it folds space. This allows starships to take near-instantaneous journeys between star systems, enabling communication and trade and keeping the Imperium whole and intact.

Thus, the Spacing Guild has a monopoly on foldspace travel and is the de facto sole supplier of transport within the Imperium. Their ships, known as **Heighliners**, are immense enough to contain all the transports and frigates of a dozen Great Houses. All passengers must abide by the Guild's strict rule of non-violence and non-interference with one another while being transported by the Guild, for fear of losing the right to book passage with the Guild, however expensive it is. Without the Guild's ability to move trade goods between star systems, a House's wealth is constrained, its power within the Landsraad dwindled.

The ability to fold space is exclusive to the Guild and its Navigators. Any attempts at computerized navigation have been rigorously outlawed by the Butlerian Edicts, though some attempts are made in secrecy to duplicate the long-forbidden technology or to mimic the ability, usually resulting in calamity or, at best, lesser quality. Interstellar travel without foldspace is still possible, even commonplace, but due to its relative slowness, those who can afford to use the Guild's services do so, and non-foldspace travel is primarily reserved for those who can neither afford it, have no urgency to their travel or delivery of goods, or would prefer their travel be done outside the awareness of the Guild for a variety of reasons.

The Spacing Guild and Guild Navigators are described on p.47.

CHOAM

All trade within the Imperium is governed and regulated by the Combine Honnette Ober Advancer Mercantiles—an immense organization usually referred to solely by its initials CHOAM. Every House within the Landsraad has shares in CHOAM and draws profits from it. CHOAM assesses taxes on goods, regulates trade, and sets economic policies affecting trade between Houses. The most lucrative of all trade goods CHOAM manages is, of course, spice, and the economic health of the Imperium is measured by the market value of melange at any given time.

Like the Spacing Guild, which owns a silent partnership within it, CHOAM is integrated into every part of the structure of the Landsraad, and thus its influence is felt everywhere. Nearly everything that is bought or sold within the Imperium is regulated by CHOAM, so vast and pervasive is its influence. Though every House and the Emperor himself are shareholders and collect a portion of its revenue, the collective power of CHOAM itself is such that all must bow to its dictates or face an audit, or potential financial ruin.

The public face of CHOAM is its President, currently Frankos Aru, who governs the business aspects of the vast company from the landmark known as the Silver Needle, not far from the Imperial Palace on Kaitain. The true power behind CHOAM, however, is the ur-director, or 'urdir', Malina Aru, mother of the President, current head of a long-standing dynasty.

As the largest minority shareholder in CHOAM, the Emperor is functionally its chief officer. Other Houses covet and strive for directorships within its bureaucracy, which the Emperor can grant or revoke as he sees fit. The Spacing Guild and even the Bene Gesserit hold shares of CHOAM and influence its decision-making to some degree, though the Spacing Guild and CHOAM's operations are deeply intertwined.

CHOAM is covered on p.43.

IMPERIAL SARDAUKAR

Trained exclusively within the harsh environment of the so-called 'prison planet' of Salusa Secundus, the Sardaukar are the Emperor's feared shock troops that he and he alone commands. They are how the Emperor holds the Landsraad at bay, the ever-present threat of the Sardaukar looming above all. So great is the fear that the Sardaukar strike into the Landsraad that the Emperor regularly wears the uniform of an officer of the Sardaukar, to remind his enemies and allies alike of his command over them, though he has not trained as one.

Indeed, the Sardaukar training regimen is a brutal one that costs many cadets their lives, due to its rigors and the harsh environment on Salusa Secundus. Those that survive, the resulting soldiers, are fanatically loyal to House Corrino and their Padishah Emperor, cultivating a reputation for being the most fearsome troops within the Imperium.

Sardaukar battle uniforms are white, and ritually stained in blood. They can wear whatever clothing and armor are required for a particular battle or assignment. But the Emperor usually wants his enemies to know what they face; such is the fear they inspire. Each is usually equipped with a variety of armaments as required: helmet, sword, dagger, sidearm, throwing knives, personal shield, as well as a variety of concealed weapons, ranging from shigawire garottes in their hair, poison needles, flip-darts, weapons in fake digits or teeth, etc. Their most favored weapon is the blade, but their battle suits never include a scabbard as it is never sheathed.

Sardaukar are also trained in covert operations, disguise, infiltration, psychological warfare, and piloting. Each is more than a match for a score of normal soldiers and consider themselves peerless, save perhaps only the highest-level Swordsmen of Ginaz. Their fighting style, however, is distinctive, relying on teamwork, and for this they are easily recognized when deployed in combat.

LIFE WITHIN THE IMPERIUM

The overwhelming majority of humans living within the Imperium are subject to the Fauflreluches and are as such hereditary peasants whose destiny is to serve the *siridar* governor appointed by the House, who in turn serve at the will of the Emperor. This system ensures that all understand their role within it, and the certainty that one is acting according to the social order ensures peace and relative ease from uncertainty. That is what the nobility insists at any rate, and no one ever asks the peasantry what they think.

The standard unit of currency is the **solari**, a denomination that has been tied to the value of the spice melange, again underlining the importance of spice to the Imperium. This currency is enforced by CHOAM and thus allows free trade everywhere, eliminating money-changing and conversion that can potentially cut into profits.

The common, and official, tongue spoken everywhere in the Imperium is **Galach**. Regional and planetary variants exist and many, many other languages are spoken within the fiefdoms of the various Houses of the Landsraad, but most official communication is done in Galach. In turn, invented languages are commonplace, from the finger-signs of the Bene Gesserit, battle languages unique to each House, and *Chakobsa*, the hunting tongue used by the Bene Gesserit and Fremen.

Traditionally, life within the Fauflreluches system is simple, with most people within it serving as some sort of laborers or craftsmen, with some few appointed positions of administration. Ultimately, everyone knows that they, their families, and everyone they know serve two masters: their *siridar* governor and the Emperor. Resources and goods are produced, from the humble pundi rice and moonfish exports of Caladan to the priceless soostones of Buzzell, and are proffered to the House for distribution within their domains and for profit, exported off-planet and sold within the Landsraad, usually with CHOAM getting their cut. CHOAM, in turn, distributes a portion of their shares as dividends to the Houses that encompass the Landsraad and to the Emperor himself, for there is a perfect overlap of the two. Thus, the system sustains itself: labor provides the Houses with their wealth which enriches CHOAM which enriches the Houses and the Emperor.

THE IMPERIAL HOUSEHOLD

The court and household of the Corrino Padishah Emperor is perhaps the most opulent in all human history. Possessing wealth beyond imagination as well as the *de facto* owner of the Imperium itself, the Emperor knows for no want. His personal estate is beyond comparison, and his spouse and children have sumptuous

apartments within the palace on Kaitain, the Imperial Capital, in which also rests the Golden Lion Throne. The Imperial Household consists of thousands of servants and has at its disposal the most up-to-date technology and luxuries that the Imperium can offer. The Emperor's capital ship is essentially a mobile castle capable of housing thousands of Sardaukar, a symbol of his invincibility.

NOBLE HOUSES

Most Houses—Major and Minor—live lives of relative luxury compared to those they rule over. Whether daunting fortresses or medieval-style castles, or even sumptuous estates, those of noble birth usually have excellent food and drink, ready access to spice, tailored clothing, comfortable and spacious quarters, elegantly appointed halls, technological devices such as filmbooks or glowglobes, and are served by dozens, if not hundreds, of servants. They want for nothing save intangibles like power and influence, and usually have a cadre of guards ready to defend from any attackers.

COMMONERS

The autochthons of the Imperium, people who live their entire lives within a short distance from the place they were born, live humbly, their relative comfort reflecting that of the House that governs their home planet or territory. For the more generous Houses, life can be comfortable, even pleasant. Technology beyond simple

items is generally reserved for those with wealth. Most households have no means of long-range communication, and their homes are lit by glowglobes or more natural methods.

For the common folk, there is almost no sense of social mobility. The notion that one's life path can change through self-determination, personal betterment, or through action is a quaint one, held by few. The primary means of changing one's lot in life is to join the military or enter the direct service of the House, perhaps as a servant with hopes of distinction within that role. Only by the will of one's betters is life improved.

SLAVES

The least fortunate method of change in status is through capture and enslavement. Generally, captives of worth are ransomed back to the Houses they serve, or they are simply coerced into the service of their captors through other means. However, though slavery is technically tolerated in the Imperium, it is viewed by most of the Landsraad as repugnant. Most Houses do not countenance slavery within their territory; some Houses permit it but allow slaves to purchase their freedom; and other Houses practice it openly. House Harkonnen is a notable example of the latter, practicing chattel slavery, these subjects living in constant fear and misery, subject to death at the whims of their owners.



TECHNOLOGY

The strict prohibitions of the Butlerian Jihad prevent much technological development, and though there are many other means of machinery, overt reliance on technology is somewhat distrusted by much of the Imperium. People prefer to 'do things the natural way' where possible. Two groups, House Vernius of Ix and the Tleilaxu (see p.42), each skirt the Butlerian edicts in their own way, and many innovations in technology within the Imperium are driven by them. House Richese is also well known for its technology, although just as well known for its unwillingness to push against Butlerian prescriptions for the sake of innovation. Despite this, there still exists a wide range of devices that characterize and modify day-to-day life within the Imperium. Many such devices are so advanced to be highly efficient, small, and easily concealed. This often makes technology extremely unobtrusive, offering a low-tech appearance to most places.

Most significant technological items are described on p.194-209, while an overview is presented here.

TRANSPORTATION

Aside from the spaceships of the Spacing Guild and the noble Houses, transportation throughout the Imperium range from primitive animal-powered carts to advanced groundcars, ornithopters, carryalls, crawlers, surface-to-air lighters, suspensor-held vehicles, and their like.

INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY

Communication across distances is handled with either a communinet transceiver or a method called distrans, where a recorded message is stored into the memory of a living being and 'played back' when desired, often with a required code to unlock it. Physical media includes filmbooks, shigawire readers, minimic encoders, memo-corders, and other media players and projectors.

HOUSEHOLD TECHNOLOGY

The most significant development is that of the suspensor, a gravity-defying device capable of lightening any load. From large vehicles to personal rigs, suspensors are common throughout the Imperium. Similarly, glowglobes, often fitted with suspensors, provide light cheaply and can be moved wherever desired.

Most food consumed within the Imperium is prepared by traditional means, rather than through industrial methods. Many cooks even prefer to prepare meals by hand from natural ingredients. Basic technology allows food preparation to be done quicker, more efficiently,

and possibly healthier, but the same techniques remain constant. The same applies for household cleaning and maintenance, which is why the nobility employ many servants to cook, clean, and launder for them.

As the dangers of assassination are ever present, the poison snooper is a standard fixture of most noble households, whether suspensor-propelled, handheld, or fixed.

PERSONAL ARMAMENTS

Few within the Imperium have access to sophisticated weaponry, other than members of the Houses and their retainers, and criminals such as outlaws, assassins, or smugglers. Most hand weapons consist of bladed and/or pointed weapons (swords, daggers, etc.), garrotes, or hidden darts and needles. Firearms include needle-guns, slow-pellet stunners, maula pistols, and lasguns, though the latter are restricted heavily and generally only available for those in direct service to the noble Houses.

The invention of the personal energy shield has transformed hand-to-hand fighting, and most fighters go without any more than lightly armored battle dress. Due to the Holtzman Effect the personal shield makes lasgun usage extremely dangerous, as their collision causes a pseudo-atomic explosion. Even to accidentally trigger such an explosion is considered a breach of the Great Convention and will see the responsible party brought down by the combined weight of the Landsraad. For this reason, the use of lasguns is shunned in warfare, as a stray shot can bring catastrophic destruction upon all the participants. See the sidebar on p.23 for more about this.

Young nobles also learn to fight against servo-driven combat drones, often controlled by their swordmaster trainers.

INDUSTRIAL TECHNOLOGY

Some level of manufacturing and heavy mechanized work is handled by servos, which are little better than gear and clockwork-driven automatons, incapable of doing anything other than following simple orders, physically manufactured into their construction. Suspensors, mentioned above, also play a large role in industry.

THE GREAT SCHOOLS

Over the millennia, many organizations have risen and fallen within the Imperium, with the more powerful achieving the status of Great School, venerable institutions whose very names impart confidence in those who they have trained. Most Houses within the Landsraad have one or more graduates of these schools within their ranks, and many noble heirs are either sent to these schools or taught their disciplines by graduates of these schools.

The Spacing Guild, one of the most powerful of these schools, is discussed prior on p.30.

THE BENE GESSERIT

Moving behind the scenes is the Sisterhood of the Bene Gesserit, an all-female religious order that advises and counsels all the Houses of the Landsraad, providing them with wives, concubines, and counselors. Some women within noble Houses receive Sisterhood training, whether through time spent within the order, at the hands of a mother or relative who received this training, or from a Bene Gesserit representative serving within their household. Their more advanced training includes enhanced physical and mental acuity and the ability to control their bodies to extraordinary degrees, secret means of communication and perception, and even to discern truth or deception in those they observe. Historically, the Bene Gesserit have used spice to advance their abilities, but the degree to which they are dependent upon it—if at all—is a closely-guarded secret.

Descended from a hybrid of Catholicism, Islam, Zen Buddhism, Judaism, Hinduism, and other religions, the Sisterhood has seeded the galaxy with their doctrine—the Missionaria Protectiva—to preserve the members of their order and give them influence, no matter where they go. Though the Bene Gesserit serves all the Houses and the Emperor, their true goal is the secret genetics program, a grand exercise in controlled eugenics. Its ultimate purpose is the creation of their Kwisatz Haderach, a genetic superhuman whose psychic and physical abilities will bring peace to the universe, all with the careful guidance and control of the Sisterhood.

The Sisterhood of the Bene Gesserit is described more fully on p.55.

THE ORDER OF MENTATS

Though the Butlerian Edicts prevent thinking computers, this does not do away with the need for complex calculations and analysis of data. To meet this need, the Order of Mentats was founded, humans capable of sophisticated feats of cognition and analysis, with enhanced memories and thought processes capa-

ble of making intuitive leaps and predicting human behavior and outcomes with astonishing accuracy. As such, Mentats are supreme strategists, administrators, spymasters, and counselors, relying on a state called the 'naïve mind', which allows them to assess incoming information without prejudice or assumptions. Though this is not as accurate as actual prescience, Mentats are nonetheless essential to most House-level strategy and action.

Most Mentats drink Sapho juice, extracted from the roots of the ecaz tree, which enhances their mental processing abilities tremendously, but marks their lips with a telltale red stain.

THE SUK SCHOOL

A necessity for any House is a qualified and skilled physician, capable of administering to the health and well-being of the noble family and its retainers. Many schools of physicians exist throughout the Imperium, but none have the prestige of the Suk School, whose graduates are said to be as incorruptible as they are skilled, compassionate healers unfailingly loyal to their employers, incapable of taking a life in even the most extraordinary of circumstances.

The diamond forehead tattoo is the symbol of the Suk school's guarantee. This is invaluable, as the very lives of a noble House are in the hands of their doctor, as well as their secrets. This reliability comes with a price: the Suk doctors are among the most expensive in the Imperium, a portion of their considerable earnings claimed by their school.

THE SWORDMASTERS OF GINAZ

Swordmasters serve as commanders, generals, security officers, and personal bodyguards. They often oversee the tutelage of nobles in the fighting arts, both for the nobles' own safety and to ready these students for the responsibilities they assume should they inherit their House's leadership. All Houses within the Landsraad employ swordmasters within their ranks, though the ones from Ginaz are indisputably the best. Famed throughout the Imperium, its graduates are among the finest warriors the galaxy has seen, perhaps even capable of besting Imperial Sardaukar. Their training is not limited to swordsmanship (in which they are without peer) but also all manner of hand-to-hand combat, armed or unarmed, shielded or otherwise, as well as tactics, command, demolition, logistics, and all the arts of war.

FAITH AND RELIGION

While humanity has spread out into the stars, religion and faith still have a place in the Imperium. In fact, several religious beliefs form the cornerstone of many of the social mores of both nobles and commoners. Most of the faiths of Old Terra have survived in one form or another, and many have found common ground with others to form new religious philosophies. Some of these faiths are practiced only in one community; others have adherents across the Imperium.

ORANGE CATHOLICISM

Many within the Imperium follow a religion known as **Orange Catholicism**, named for the *Orange Catholic Bible*, a controversial religious tract developed after the Butlerian Jihad. Though the Imperium has no official state religion and many creeds are followed within it, Orange Catholicism is perhaps the most widespread of the faiths.

The religion incorporates a wide range of religious creeds from Old Terra, a fusion religion synthesized by the Committee of Ecumenical Translators (the CET). The goal of the CET was to create the 'perfect' religious book that could accommodate the spiritual needs of all humanity, taking away from any single religion the claim to being the sole proprietor of divine insight. This collection of religious writings was compiled after the Butlerian Jihad from a mixture of faiths, but particularly Judaism, Islam, and Christianity. However, it is not simply a mixture of religious texts thrown together, but a carefully curated gospel for the new era of humanity. As such many of its writings warn against the return of 'thinking machines' and the arrogance of humanity in seeking to create such new life.

The publication of the *Orange Catholic Bible* was marked with controversy, with great riots throughout the Imperium, and it was denounced vigorously for centuries to come. Despite this, it is nonetheless the primary source for the most popular religion of the Imperium.

The primary commandment of the Orange Catholic Bible is "Thou shalt not disfigure the soul." The book itself, often referred to as the OCB, its initials, is nearly 1,800 pages long, and is oft quoted by scholars and pious folk alike, and all noble educations consist of some reading within its many pages.

Despite the ubiquity of the OCB and its tenets, most within the Landsraad, from the noble Houses to the humblest of their servants, generally only pay lip service to the religion, and few are particularly devout.

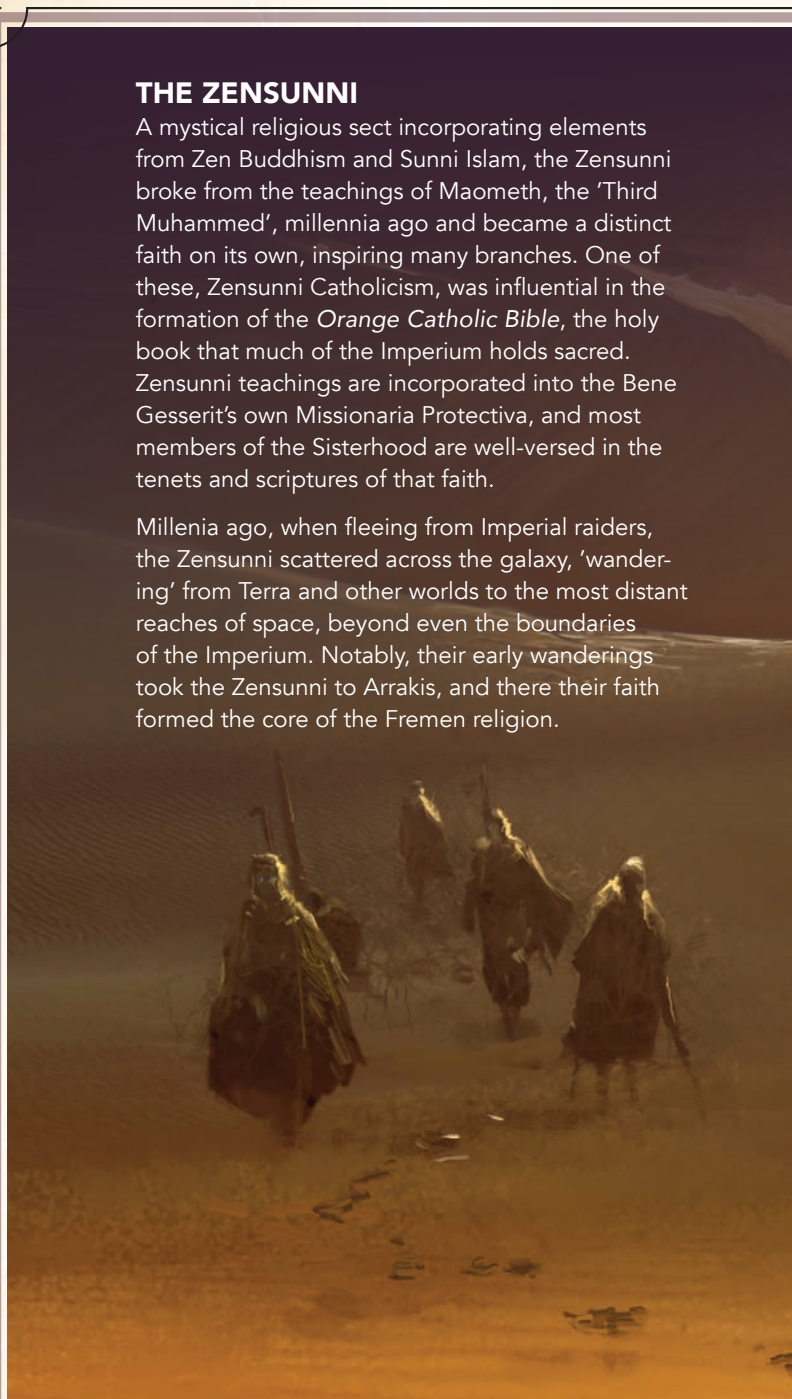
It is important to remember the Butlerian Jihad was not just a war, but a holy war. Humanity did not just fight to free themselves from the tyranny of the think-

ing machines for their own sake, they did so because God commanded it. The freedom of humanity was a gift from God for doing his will and tearing down the enslaving machines. The desperation of the fight and the many moments it felt hopeless, brought humanity closer to religion and prayer to gain hope against such a vast and powerful enemy. Since that time humanity has believed that it was their faith that allowed them to prevail, and that without it, God may take his gift of freedom away. Thus, the proscriptions against creating thinking machines are not just a rule, but a holy covenant with God. Many believe that to break them, in any way, will bring ruin to not only the perpetrator, but their family, House, and possibly all humanity.

THE ZENSUNNI

A mystical religious sect incorporating elements from Zen Buddhism and Sunni Islam, the Zensunni broke from the teachings of Maometh, the 'Third Muhammed', millennia ago and became a distinct faith on its own, inspiring many branches. One of these, Zensunni Catholicism, was influential in the formation of the *Orange Catholic Bible*, the holy book that much of the Imperium holds sacred. Zensunni teachings are incorporated into the Bene Gesserit's own Missionaria Protectiva, and most members of the Sisterhood are well-versed in the tenets and scriptures of that faith.

Millenia ago, when fleeing from Imperial raiders, the Zensunni scattered across the galaxy, 'wandering' from Terra and other worlds to the most distant reaches of space, beyond even the boundaries of the Imperium. Notably, their early wanderings took the Zensunni to Arrakis, and there their faith formed the core of the Fremen religion.



Despite its origins, adherents of the Orange Catholic faith do not generally participate in organized worship. While there are priests and advisors, faith is a matter for the practitioner. Like many of the religions of the Imperium, the Orange Catholic Faith is more of a philosophy to be studied than a set of rituals to be followed. Adherents generally read and reread the OC Bible to memorize its warnings and understand the truth of its laws and moral guidance. Prayers are offered to God in the same way they always have been. But many prayers are also offered for the faithful to keep the covenant and for humanity to not transgress its strictures. Those who follow the faith generally consider themselves the guardians of God's covenant with humanity against thinking machines. They watch for signs that someone, in their arrogance, might push the limits of the strictures past their breaking point and bring ruin to humanity.

Given the lack of organized worship, there is quite a lot of divergence among adherents about the specifics of the Orange Catholic faith. While they are all working from the same text, different conclusions might be made over the same passages. Thankfully, this doesn't generally lead to conflict except among the most fanatical followers. Study of the holy book is encouraged, and new interpretations are welcomed as they lead to greater understanding of God's will. It is up to the adherent to decide for themselves which interpretations they will follow, and there is no shame in changing your mind. In fact, the truly faithful are constantly readjusting the details of their faith as they come to understand its complexities.

ATHEISM IN THE IMPERIUM

While not everyone follows a religion, it is quite difficult to be an atheist in the Imperium. The continued existence of humanity is generally taken to be evidence of God, as it was the will of God that saved humanity. Despite this somewhat circular argument, this idea is so ingrained in Imperium society it is hard to shake. Anyone who declares there is no God is considered dangerous. They may break the covenant, unaware of the consequences, or worse, because they don't believe there are any. This generally means that most atheists quickly learn to keep their opinion to themselves.

Though the sisters of the Bene Gesserit, cloaked as they are in mysticism and ritual, learn the contents of the OCB in apprenticeship, they are not believers in Orange Catholicism, viewing the very construct of religion as a tool which the Sisterhood can use as it needs to, and little beyond that. Their own *Azhar Book* predates the OCB and serves as their own handbook for manipulating religion to suit their purposes.

While most study the OC Bible as children and are brought up with the main strictures of the Butlerian Jihad, that is often as far as most people take their faith. Such people would agree that God exists, but beyond

that, faith takes little part in their lives. In some places, usually ones with a greater focus on technology (such as Ix), the Butlerian strictures are an annoying limit on innovation. However, even the most ardent technologist might push these limits but would never break them. Even if God doesn't arrive to punish them and ruin their House, the Imperium and Landsraad certainly will.

OTHER FAITHS & PRECEPTS

While most cultures across the Imperium follow the main dictates of the Butlerian Jihad, there is a wide variety of small religions across the various planets and communities. It is in these communities that faith finds its most dedicated adherents. Religion generally reflects the life of the people who follow it. Thus, communities on barren desert planets and lush forest worlds have different needs in their religious life. A simple fisherman or water seller is not especially worried they will create a thinking machine. They pray for good weather and a plentiful harvest. So, in the feudal society of the Imperium, the faith followed by the nobility is often quite different from that of the workers and peasantry, no matter how beneficent the ruler.

The folk religions of the Imperium are no less complex than those of the nobility, but they have a greater emphasis on community. Religious ties and a shared belief are often what bind the community together. This means that many communities participate in group worship, working together to ask for blessings from their deity. The same is often the case for rituals like weddings and funerals, with the whole community coming together to celebrate or mourn.

While many folk religions develop in communities on planets across the universe, they are not as isolated as you might think. There are many stories of pilgrims (such as the renowned Zensunni Wanderers) who have moved from planet to planet seeking homes or avoiding persecution. Unsurprisingly, such groups change and are changed by the cultures they encounter, and in this way even the most obscure religion might draw from a mixture of divergent philosophies.

One influence that cannot be understated is that of the Bene Gesserit's Missionaria Protectiva. This arm of the Sisterhood makes a point of seeking out community faiths and introducing new ideas into their mythology. These new philosophies are designed to allow the Bene Gesserit to manipulate the community through their faith, and grant any Sister lost in a strange community a way to ensure her survival. The Missionaria Protectiva is so widespread that many communities (openly or clandestinely) have a representative or agent of the Bene Gesserit among them leading their faith as a priestess, perhaps even unaware of her connection to the Sisterhood.

THE LANDSRAAD

More than 10,000 years old, the Imperium represents the entirety of humankind's expansion into the universe, the culmination of human history. Within the Imperium, almost all humans fall under the jurisdiction of Major and Minor Houses known as the Landsraad. Its reach is unmatched, a grand and all-encompassing feudal hierarchy with the Galactic Padishah Emperor at its peak.

The Landsraad's primary strength is as a counter to the Emperor. Together, its militaries would likely outmatch even the Emperor's vaunted Sardaukar, and thus a stalemate keeps the peace, each side knowing that full engagement would be ruinous to both sides.

Votes are allocated by the size and power of each House within the Landsraad, with Houses generally holding multiple votes. The Major Houses have most of the votes, while Houses Minor claim a lesser bloc, and are unlikely to influence policy unless there is an impasse. As a Major House, the Emperor's own House Corrino's votes have considerable weight, as well, but even he cannot outvote the rest of the Landsraad should it unite against him.

The Landsraad meets regularly, the House heads from across the Imperium converging to discuss matters of great import, such as conducting trade and establishing policy. The meetings are traditionally held on Kaitain, but not always. Within the Landsraad is a select High Council of House leaders, and this group intercedes in conflicts between member Houses. The High Council has the power to authorize whether declarations of *kanly* (p.206) are legitimate, and to recognize when any House has violated the terms of the Great Convention.

THE GREAT CONVENTION

All Houses are signees to the Great Convention, a treaty whose laws keep all Houses in check against one another, as well as binding the Spacing Guild and CHOAM to codes of behavior. This treaty, derived from the Guild Peace put into place by the Spacing Guild (see p.22), dates to the period immediately after the Butlerian Jihad, when the Houses of the Imperium strove against one another for supremacy.

There are many smaller laws within the Great Convention, but the primary ones are as follows:

- ☞ Internecine wars between Houses must be conducted under the code of *kanly*, vendettas formally recognized by the Landsraad and holding to certain standards of conduct. This extends to the use of assassins as a method of settling disputes.
- ☞ Indiscriminate use of mass weapons of destruction, specifically atomics and biological weapons, is prohibited due to the potential for civilian casualties.
- ☞ The Emperor must remain neutral in all conflicts between Houses, as he must serve as an impartial arbiter when disputes become matters for the Landsraad to decide.
- ☞ The Emperor may determine and mete out justice when a House has transgressed against the laws of the Great Convention, though this power is used sparingly and with the Landsraad's oversight.



THE FAUFRELUCHES CASTE SYSTEM

The Fauflreluches is the governing political structure that holds the Landsraad together. A form of hereditary feudalism as has existed many times throughout human history, the Fauflreluches caste system is the hierarchical organization that extends from the Emperor to the Major Houses, to the Houses Minor, then to the *siridar* governors, who administrate Imperial Law upon individual planets. The Emperor owns all within the Imperium, and it is only by the Emperor's will that planetary fiefdoms are granted to be administered by the Houses of the Landsraad.

The unofficial motto of the Landsraad is "A place for every man, and every man has a place." Though simplistic, this nonetheless spells out exactly what the social order is within the Fauflreluches caste system. People are born into their station, and their status rarely, if ever, changes. All must accept their fate in life and contribute to the best of their abilities, whether through toil or tending to the needs of those they lord over.

At the top of the caste system are the nobles of the Houses of the Landsraad. Born to privilege, they are wealthy and have status, power, and influence beyond any that normal citizens can ever attain. Within a House and the Landsraad itself, the distinction between Houses Minor and Houses Major is of immense interest and concern; to those outside the House these distinctions are relatively meaningless. A noble is a noble, whether they control one planet or several.

NOBLE HOUSES

The pinnacle of the caste system, the Houses are hereditary dynasties, title passing down from the House's head to their designated heir. Within a House, however, is a microcosm of the Fauflreluches hierarchy. A House is not just the head noble—baroness, duke, or countess—and their immediate family, including any spouses or heirs: it

includes allies, employees, servants, inhabitants of their ancestral lands, and their slaves, if any.

The titled head of the household is its owner, the member of the Landsraad, owner of the CHOAM shares, and the ultimate arbiter of the House's vote within the Landsraad. Their lawfully recognized spouse is generally not the inheritor of the title but does hold some degree of influence if there is no clear heir. In some cases, they may vote in the Landsraad and inherit holdings, but this must be done with the approval of the Emperor and the Landsraad.

Many House leaders also keep concubines, often married for reasons of love or to produce an heir. The leader of a House may in some cases have a married spouse and one (or more) concubines. A concubine cannot inherit a title or holdings and cannot vote within the Landsraad. Their fates are often uncertain if control of the House changes hands, especially should they shift towards a spouse or an heir they are not the parent of.

The heir of the household is the eldest son or daughter, or another direct relation if the existing elder child is unsuitable for some reason. Subsequent noble children are essentially of noble status but have little else attached to their name, other than status within the House. Though a young lord or lady may have a great

many virtues and abilities to contribute to the House's fortune, their worth is primarily for the alliances they can make through marriage. Their fates are often determined by the disposition of their parents and the heir, whomever that might be. Many enter service into one of the Great Schools, seeking to chart their own course in life, and others attach themselves to the Imperial court, seeking to perhaps better their station outside their own House.

In some cases, the leader of a House might abdicate to a trusted relative, whether a brother or sister, or the Emperor himself may intervene and place a chosen member of the House in control. The Landsraad might intervene in circumstances where this is not clear or contested. Finally, the Emperor could command a House to divest itself of its holdings, to relocate, to surrender property to another House, but ultimately, he cannot strip a noble of their title, except in the most extraordinary of conditions. This is a dramatic move, and generally the Landsraad would rebel if this is done indiscriminately, for if the Emperor is able to unseat any noble with impunity, none of them are safe and the Landsraad's power is undermined entirely.

The most recent instance of this intervention was with House Vernius of Ix, forced to become renegade when they ran afoul of the Emperor for a variety of reasons, specifically development of technology that violated



the prohibitions of the Butlerian Edicts. After a considerable fall from grace, House Vernius petitioned to restore their status. This was granted, but the damage was done, and now the House is but a shadow of its former strength and is now more a technocrat confederacy than a true House.

The self-preservation of a House and its continuation is its highest priority, and thus the head of the House and their family are protected by a force of guards, poison-snoopers, trusted advisors, and defensive tactics. Heirs are trained in the arts of swordsmanship, tactics, logistics, and negotiation, as well as gaining a deep understanding of the history of the Landsraad, its practices, and processes, so that they might lead their House in the future. Many Houses bring Bene Gesserit tutors to train their daughters, to add those abilities to the strength of the House. In return, the Bene Gesserit often become wives or concubines of male House leaders, bearing children as part of their secretive breeding program.

LEGAL PROCESSES OF THE LANDSRAAD

The primary means by which a House appeals when its rights have been violated is by submitting a **Bill of Particulars** to the Landsraad's High Council. A formal process, this is a legal document that details any grievances or offenses committed against a House, and generally makes an accusation of one House violating the Great Convention. The matter is brought for review, and the High Council votes on how to proceed. If the offending party is found guilty, a penalty is levied, generally financial but sometimes requiring loss of holdings.

When a ruling of the High Council requires such a transfer of assets, a **Judge of the Change** is appointed, usually by the Emperor. This position is hereditary. The Judge's duty is to preside over the process and to report to the Emperor that all forms are followed, and that the penalized House does not behave egregiously or further violate the Great Convention. Historically, all Houses respect the Judge's authority, but they may challenge any decisions the Judge makes.

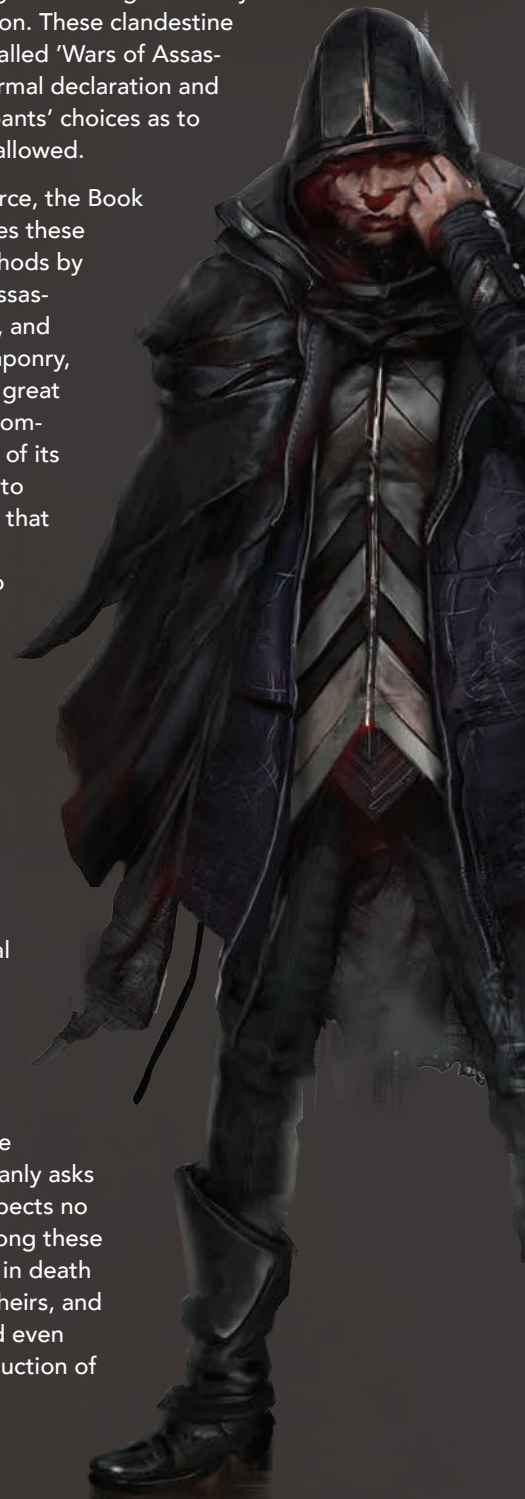
The most severe punishment to be levied by the High Council is that of banishment, where a House is divested entirely of its holdings and forced to seek refuge, either on the outskirts of the Imperium where the Landsraad does not extend, or even outside the Imperium entirely, generally thought to be a death sentence. In some cases, a refugee House may be sheltered by another House, but this is rare, as it risks Imperial disfavor—and likely consequences—upon both Houses equally.

THE WAR OF ASSASSINS

Open warfare is generally prohibited between Houses except in extraordinary circumstances such as retaliation or when sanctioned by the Emperor, who uses this permission sparingly. This keeps the Imperium relatively stable and prevents innocent civilians—and resources—from being harmed. Thus, one of the sole means of waging war between Houses is under specific terms and guidelines agreed to by the Great Convention. These clandestine engagements are called 'Wars of Assassins', requiring a formal declaration and limiting the participants' choices as to what weapons are allowed.

An Old Earth resource, the Book of Assassins, outlines these guidelines and methods by which the War of Assassins might proceed, and lists prohibited weaponry, updated to include great weapons such as atomics. A great portion of its pages are devoted to the various poisons that might be used, the best methods to do so, and under what conditions they are allowed.

Kanly, an ancient word from Old Earth, describes a certain type of War of Assassins, 'the art of vendetta', a particularly personal dispute. A War of Assassins might be about a business deal or political differences, and an end could be negotiated, while kanly asks no quarters and expects no mercy. A conflict along these lines usually results in death of a House's head, heirs, and household, or could even extend to the destruction of an entire House.



HOUSES OF THE IMPERIUM



he various Houses of the Landsraad govern the Imperium and hold most of its wealth and political power. Most are descended from some Old Earth dynasty and have existed for thousands of years, frequently based on an ancestral holding upon their home planet. Though these planets are usually hereditary, they are technically 'owned' by the Emperor and granted as fiefdoms.

Houses are described by their reach and size, and include:

- The Imperial House, of which there has been only one for the past ten thousand years: House Corrino.
- Great Houses, the wealthiest and most powerful of all the Houses. Great Houses control more than their home planet and its natural satellites, their territories encompassing several planets and moons, sometimes across different star systems. This distinction is often interchangeable with that of the Major House.
- Major Houses, or Houses Major, often limited to a single planet and its moons, but occasionally extend to additional planets and moons within a single solar system. Often Great and Major Houses are considered together in the Landsraad, and as noted above, the term is at times used interchangeably.
- Minor Houses, or Houses Minor, which are smaller and less influential Houses that have pledged fealty to a House Major and govern some portion of its territory, or even control over a single industry rather than territory. A House Major may have many Houses Minor sworn to it.

It is rare, but not unheard of, for a House to change its status as its fortunes and influence shifts, and at times, a House's designation does not indicate its relative influence within the Landsraad. Some of the more significant Houses of the Imperium are described below.

HOUSE CORRINO

The most powerful single House in the Landsraad and thus in the Known Universe, the Imperial House Corrino has held control over the Imperium since the Battle of Corrin, 10,000 years ago, with only a few brief interruptions. A Corrino descendant has sat upon the Golden Lion Throne ever since the foundation of the Imperium itself. The Imperial throne world is Kaitain, center of the Padishah Emperor Shaddam IV's court. Their original ancestral homeworld is the planet Salusa Secundus, an inhospitable prison planet rumored to be the training ground of the Emperor's deadly shock troops, the Sardaukar.

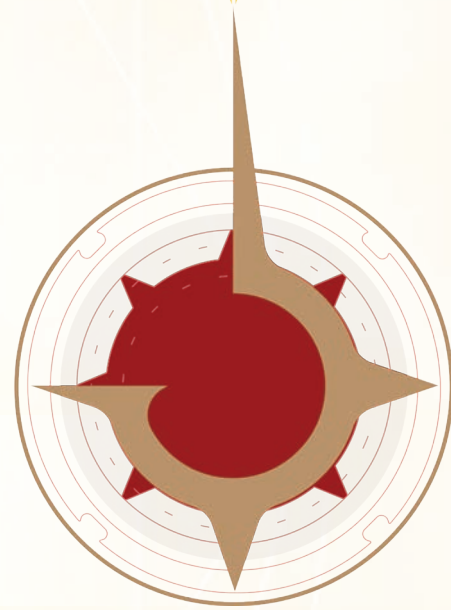


HOUSE HARKONNEN

One of the more powerful Great Houses, House Harkonnen is based on Giedi Prime, a planet they have stripped all wealth from, a dismal place under totalitarian rule. To many within the Landsraad, the Harkonnen name is a synonym for treachery, and the Harkonnen family does little to discourage this reputation. Reveling in their brutality and inhuman subjugation of those they govern, the Harkonnens grew to power through underhanded business practices and outright hostility to their fellow Houses.

For many years, the Harkonnens held the rights and responsibility of mining Arrakis for its spice, a period in which they made a vast fortune and many enemies among the planet's natives and their rivals within the Landsraad.

Life within Harkonnen territory is full of conspiracy and fear, with everyone pitted against another for survival and dominance. They are one of the few Great Houses to not only continue the practice of slavery, but to inflict immeasurable misery upon those souls. Only the strong and merciless thrive within House Harkonnen under their leader, the Siridar Baron Vladimir Harkonnen, a decadent and evil man whose ambition would place him, or one of his heirs, upon the throne of the Imperium itself.



HOUSE ATREIDES

House Atreides is a well-respected House, ruled over by Duke Leto Atreides, who inherited the title from his father Paulus, who was killed in a bullfight. Claiming descent from the ancient King Agamemnon, son of Atreus, of Old Terra, the Atreides are among the most ancient households of the Landsraad.

The ducal seat and Atreides homeworld is the water-bound planet Caladan, thought to be a relatively humble planet, primarily known for its production of pundi rice, an inexpensive staple food consumed everywhere throughout the Imperium. Their holdings are relatively technologically unsophisticated, almost rustic, though the folk the Atreides rule are relatively content, and live lives of simplicity and quality.

Duke Leto is as liked within his own domain as he is within the Landsraad, where he is renowned for his wisdom, his compassion, as well as his shrewdness. Many other House leaders turn to him for guidance, and his influence is so great that even the Emperor has taken notice.

